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Endgame Fundamentals

King activity, pawn logic, rook activity, conversion, and practical defense

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS	20

01. Read The Pawn Skeleton



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Read direction, breaks, and fixed targets before choosing a plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

CHAINS: Find each chain's base and direction.; BREAKS: List realistic pawn breaks for both sides.; TARGETS: Mark pawns that cannot easily move.; SIDE: Play where your structure gives space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I will attack the king' with 'First see where your pawns point.'; Replace 'That pawn is weak' with 'Ask whether it can be reached.'; Replace 'A pawn move gains space' with 'Check which square it permanently weakens.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

MEMORY RULE

Let the pawns tell you where your pieces belong.

01. Decision Framework

Read The Pawn Skeleton

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FREEZE: Imagine the pieces removed.; TRACE: Follow both pawn chains.; BREAKS: Name each side's freeing move.; PLACE: Put pieces behind the likely break.; ACT: Prepare the break or prevent theirs.
PIECE JOB	DIRECTION: A pawn chain points toward the space you can gain.; BREAKS: Pawn breaks decide which files and diagonals will open.; TARGETS: Fixed pawns define long-term weaknesses.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	MAP: The skeleton predicts the battlefield.; BASE: Attack chains near their foundation.; BREAK: Prepare pawn moves with pieces first.; FIX: A target matters when it cannot escape.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

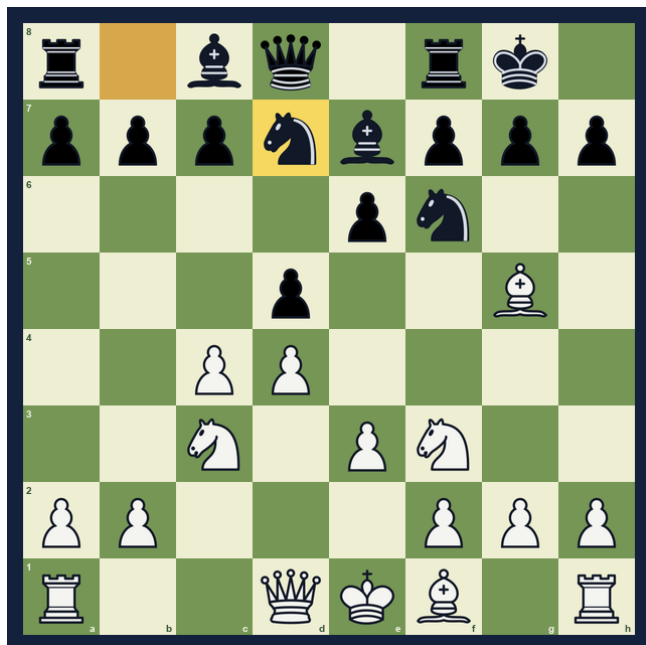
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Let the pawns tell you where your pieces belong.

02. Spot The Real Weakness



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Call it real only if you can attack it, increase pressure, or force passivity.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Can a piece reach the target safely?; PRESSURE:

Can you add attackers faster than defenders?;

CONCESSION: What does defense force them to abandon?;

MOBILITY: Can the target simply move away?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is an isolated pawn' with 'Prove you can reach and pressure it.'; Replace 'I attacked it once' with 'Add pressure or improve elsewhere.'; Replace 'They defended it' with 'Notice what their defender stopped doing.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Attack weaknesses that force the opponent to live differently.

02. Decision Framework

Spot The Real Weakness

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Choose one possible target.; REACH: Find your best attacking route.; ADD: Locate a second attacker.; RESTRICT: Prevent the target from escaping.; EXPLOIT: Use the passivity you created.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Your pieces need a practical route to the target.; PRESSURE: You must be able to add another attacker.; CONCESSION: Defending it should restrict the opponent elsewhere.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	REACHABLE: A label alone does not create a weakness.; FIXED: Targets are valuable when they cannot move.; GROWING: Pressure must be able to increase.; PASSIVITY: The defender's burden is often the real prize.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack weaknesses that force the opponent to live differently.

03. When To Trade Pieces



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Evaluate the position after the exchange, not the pieces disappearing from it.

PRIMARY PLAN

REMOVE: Which opponent piece is most useful?
 STRUCTURE: What pawn structure remains?; ENDGAME: Who benefits from fewer pieces?; ACTIVITY: Which remaining piece gains freedom?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Equal pieces can be traded' with 'Picture what improves after the trade.'; Replace 'I am ahead, so simplify' with 'Keep enough activity to convert.'; Replace 'Trade their attacker' with 'Check whether its replacement is stronger.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

03. Decision Framework

When To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PICTURE: Remove both pieces mentally.; RECOUNT: Compare the remaining active pieces.; STRUCTURE: Inspect recaptures and new pawn targets.; ENDGAME: Judge the likely simplified position.; DECIDE: Trade only for a named benefit.
PIECE JOB	RELIEF: Exchange the opponent's piece that creates the most pressure.; STRUCTURE: Use trades that leave a durable target or passed pawn.; ENDGAME: Simplify when the remaining position is easier for you to play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUTURE: An exchange is a positional transformation.; BEST PIECE: Trade what makes their position work.; RECAPTURE: The recapturing piece may gain activity.; CONVERSION: Simplification helps only if the ending helps.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

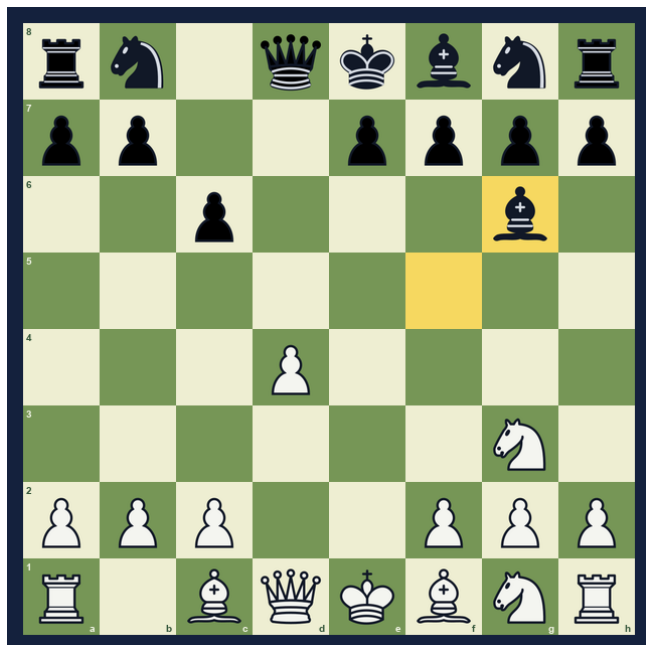
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

04. When Not To Trade Pieces



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Decline exchanges when your piece, space, or tension forces the opponent to remain uncomfortable.

PRIMARY PLAN

SPACE: Who needs room more urgently?; PRESSURE: Which piece maintains a useful burden?; TENSION: What options disappear after the exchange?; REPLACEMENT: What piece takes over the traded square?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They offered a trade' with 'Ask whose problem the trade solves.'; Replace 'Avoiding trades is passive' with 'Preserve pieces that create pressure.'; Replace 'Capture to clarify' with 'Keep tension when uncertainty favors you.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

04. Decision Framework

When Not To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not recapture automatically.; COMPARE: Identify who is cramped or pressured.; REMOVE: Visualize both pieces gone.; REPLACE: See which piece or pawn takes over.; CHOOSE: Maintain tension if it keeps options.
PIECE JOB	SPACE: The cramped side often wants pieces removed.; PRESSURE: An attacking piece may be worth more than its nominal value.; TENSION: Unresolved contact can restrict more than an immediate capture.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELIEF: Do not release a cramped opponent for free.; VALUE: Active pieces can exceed book value.; OPTIONS: Tension preserves choices and restricts replies.; PURPOSE: Every exchange should solve your problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

05. Create A Second Weakness



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Fix one weakness, then create another where the same defenders cannot serve both.

PRIMARY PLAN

FIX: Make the first weakness permanent.; TRANSFER: Prepare pieces to switch flanks.; CREATE: Produce a second point of entry.; SWITCH: Attack whichever target is underdefended.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Pile onto one pawn' with 'Fix it, then widen the battlefield.'; Replace 'Change sides immediately' with 'Prepare a fast transfer first.'; Replace 'Force the breakthrough' with 'Let overload create the breakthrough.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

Make the defender choose which weakness to lose.

05. Decision Framework

Create A Second Weakness

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FIX: Stop the first target escaping.; TIE: Force a defender into passivity.; PREPARE: Centralize pieces for transfer.; CREATE: Open a distant weakness.; SWITCH: Attack the slower defensive side.
PIECE JOB	FIX: Prevent the first target from moving or trading away.; TRANSFER: Improve pieces so they can change sides quickly.; CREATE: Use a pawn break or invasion to make a distant target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE: One weakness may only create passivity.; DISTANCE: The second target should be far away.; TRANSFER: Your pieces must switch faster.; PATIENCE: Overload wins before tactics appear.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Make the defender choose which weakness to lose.

06. Good Bishop Or Bad Bishop?



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Judge its diagonals, targets, and defensive duties in the actual position.

PRIMARY PLAN

SCOPE: Count useful squares and diagonals.; TARGETS: What can the bishop affect?; FUTURE: Which pawn break opens or closes it?; EXCHANGE: Would trading it improve the remaining structure?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Same-color pawns mean bad' with 'Check whether the bishop has a useful job.'; Replace 'Open diagonal means good' with 'Look for a real target on it.'; Replace 'Trade the bad bishop' with 'Ask what squares it currently protects.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Judge the bishop you have, not the slogan you remember.

06. Decision Framework

Good Bishop Or Bad Bishop?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TRACE: Follow every available diagonal.; FILTER: Keep only relevant destinations.; TARGET: Name what the bishop influences.; BREAK: Find the pawn move that changes its scope.; DECIDE: Improve, exchange, or preserve it.
PIECE JOB	SCOPE: Useful squares matter more than the length of a diagonal.; TARGETS: A bishop needs something relevant to attack or defend.; FUTURE: A pawn break may completely change its quality.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	JOB: A bishop's usefulness is concrete.; SCOPE: Long does not always mean relevant.; BREAK: Pawn moves can transform the piece.; DEFENSE: A restricted bishop may hold vital squares.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Judge the bishop you have, not the slogan you remember.

07. Build A Real Outpost



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Use a square that cannot be chased and from which the piece influences something important.

PRIMARY PLAN

STABLE: Can an enemy pawn challenge the square?;
SUPPORTED: Can the piece remain there safely?;
INFLUENCE: What useful squares or targets does it affect?;
ROUTE: Can the piece reach it without losing time?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is a central square' with 'Prove the piece cannot be chased.'; Replace 'A knight belongs there' with 'Ask what the knight does from there.'; Replace 'Occupy it immediately' with 'Prepare support and a safe route.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

07. Decision Framework

Build A Real Outpost

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Find squares enemy pawns cannot control.; VALUE: Choose one with real influence.; SUPPORT: Secure it with a pawn or piece.; ROUTE: Find the safest path inward.; OCCUPY: Enter when exchanges favor you.
PIECE JOB	STABILITY: Enemy pawns cannot drive the piece away.; SUPPORT: Your pawn or piece can maintain the occupant.; INFLUENCE: The square attacks targets or restricts important play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: A true outpost cannot be chased by pawns.; USEFUL: The occupant must affect the game.; SUPPORTED: Do not turn the outpost into a trap.; ROUTE: Preparation is part of occupation.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

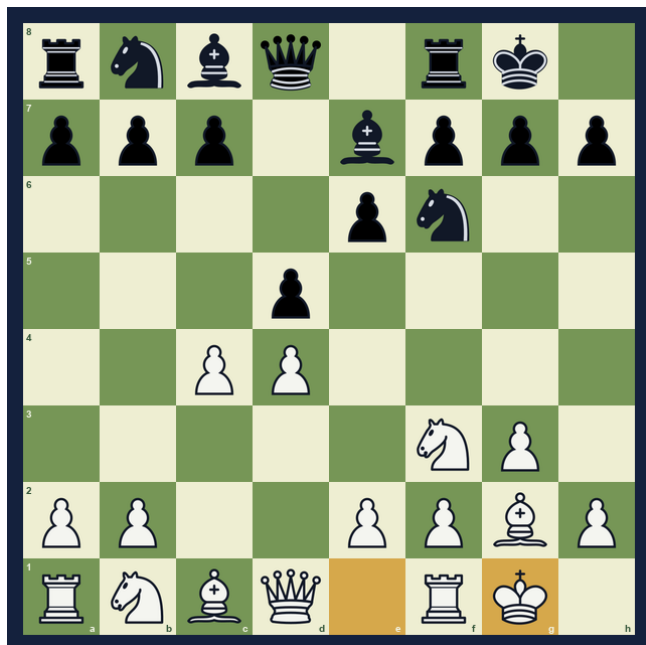
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

08. Keep Or Release The Tension?



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Compare capture, advance, and waiting before changing the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

CAPTURE: What improves after the likely recapture?; ADVANCE: What squares become fixed or weak?; WAIT: Who benefits from maintaining tension?; REPLY: Can the opponent resolve it more favorably?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Capture to simplify' with 'Inspect the opponent's recapturing piece.'; Replace 'Advance to gain space' with 'Count the squares left behind.'; Replace 'I must decide now' with 'Wait when tension restricts them more.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

08. Decision Framework

Keep Or Release The Tension?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Picture all three structural choices.; RECAPTURE: Place the opponent's piece after capture.; FIX: See what an advance makes permanent.; WAIT: Measure who has more useful options.; TIME: Resolve only for a concrete gain.
PIECE JOB	OPTIONS: Maintaining contact preserves more choices for you.; RECAPTURE: The opponent's recapturing piece may improve dramatically.; TIMING: A favorable resolution today may be unfavorable one move later.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	THREE CHOICES: Capture and advance are not the only moves.; RECAPTURE: Structure and activity change together.; OPTIONS: Tension can be a form of control.; TIMING: Resolve contact when the result favors you.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

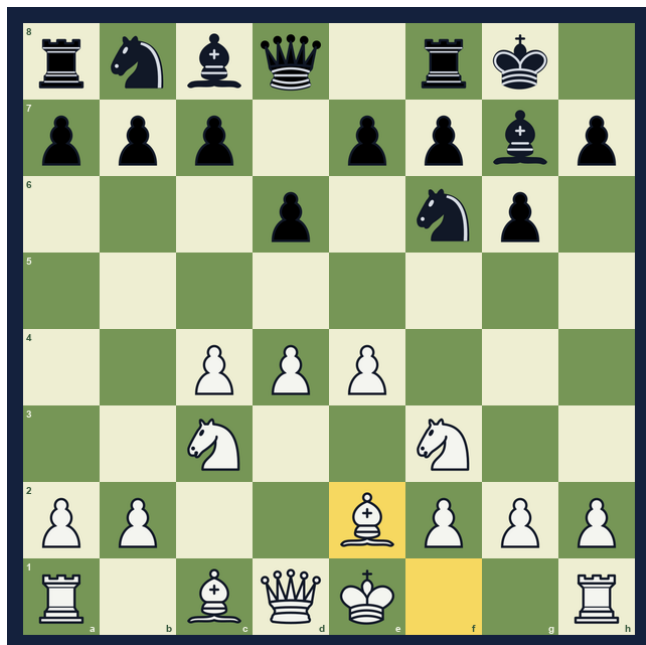
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

09. Is A Backward Pawn Really Weak?



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Judge blockade, access, and the pawn's ability to free itself.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Can heavy pieces attack the pawn?; BLOCKADE: Is the square ahead securely occupiable?; BREAK: Can the pawn advance with preparation?; COST: How passive is its defense?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Backward means weak' with 'Prove you can reach and fix it.'; Replace 'Attack the pawn directly' with 'Control the square in front first.'; Replace 'It can never move' with 'Look for a prepared freeing break.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Attack the structure only after proving it cannot repair itself.

09. Decision Framework

Is A Backward Pawn Really Weak?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LOCATE: Find the pawn and front square.; OCCUPY: Secure a blockade if possible.; PRESSURE: Bring a second attacker.; PREVENT: Stop the freeing pawn break.; EXPLOIT: Use the defender's resulting passivity.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: An attacker needs a file or route to reach it.; BLOCKADE: The square ahead can become a stable home for a piece.; BREAK: A freeing pawn move may erase the weakness entirely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	LABEL: Backward does not automatically mean weak.; SQUARE: The blockading square may be the real prize.; BREAK: Prevent the pawn's route to freedom.; COST: Win by creating defensive passivity.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

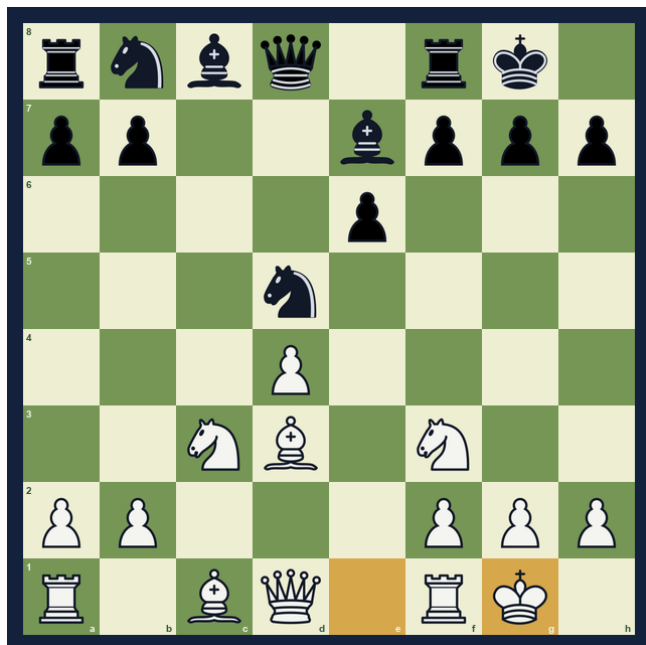
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack the structure only after proving it cannot repair itself.

10. Play With An Isolated Pawn



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Use open files, active pieces, and the central pawn break before simplifying too far.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACTIVITY: Can your pieces take active squares?; BREAK: Is the central advance tactically ready?; EXCHANGES: Which trades reduce your compensation?; TARGET: Who can blockade the pawn?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'The pawn is simply weak' with 'Use the activity it creates now.'; Replace 'Avoid every trade' with 'Keep attacking pieces, not useless ones.'; Replace 'Push it automatically' with 'Prepare the central break tactically.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

With an isolated pawn, use your time before defending becomes your only job.

10. Decision Framework

Play With An Isolated Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACTIVATE: Occupy the open files and active squares.; RESTRICT: Prevent a comfortable blockade.; PREPARE: Support the central advance.; ATTACK: Use the space near the enemy king.; TRANSFORM: Push or trade the pawn at the right moment.
PIECE JOB	SPACE: The isolated pawn grants useful central territory.; LINES: Neighboring files are open for rooks and queens.; TIMING: With fewer pieces, the pawn becomes easier to blockade and attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DYNAMIC: The weakness is balanced by active chances.; PIECES: Keep the pieces that use open lines.; BREAK: The central advance changes the position.; ENDGAME: Compensation shrinks as pieces vanish.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: With an isolated pawn, use your time before defending becomes your only job.

11. Understand Hanging Pawns



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Keep both pawns flexible until an advance gains activity or creates a passed pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

CONTROL: Which squares do both pawns influence?; MOBILITY: Can either advance safely?; ACTIVITY: Which pieces benefit from the push?; FIXATION: What target remains afterward?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push to gain space' with 'Calculate the pawn left behind.'; Replace 'Keep them forever' with 'Advance when activity justifies change.'; Replace 'They are just weaknesses' with 'Use their control while mobile.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Treat hanging pawns as stored energy, not immediate marching orders.

11. Decision Framework

Understand Hanging Pawns

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SUPPORT: Place pieces behind the pawns.; CONTROL: Use the central squares they claim.; TEST: Calculate each possible advance.; TRANSFORM: Create activity or a passed pawn.; DEFEND: Avoid a fixed, blockaded remainder.
PIECE JOB	CONTROL: Together they claim important central squares.; MOBILITY: Either pawn may advance to change the structure.; FIXATION: A careless push can leave one pawn weak forever.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	TOGETHER: Their power comes from mutual control.; MOBILE: Flexibility is part of their value.; PUSH: Advance only for activity or transformation.; REMAINDER: Always evaluate the pawn left behind.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Treat hanging pawns as stored energy, not immediate marching orders.

12. Understand The Minority Attack



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Prepare the advance with pieces and know which recapture creates the target you want.

PRIMARY PLAN

CONTACT: Where will the pawn chains meet?; RECAPTURE: Which recapture leaves a weakness?; PRESSURE: Can your pieces attack the result?; KING: Is the opposite flank safe enough?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push because it is thematic' with 'Prepare the resulting target first.'; Replace 'Win a pawn immediately' with 'Aim to create lasting passivity.'; Replace 'Ignore the kingside' with 'Check the opponent's counterplay before pushing.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

A minority attack succeeds when the new weakness lasts longer than the pawn push.

12. Decision Framework

Understand The Minority Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PREPARE: Put a rook behind the advancing pawn.; RESTRAIN: Limit the opponent's pawn advance.; CONTACT: Force the pawn chain to choose.; FIX: Create the intended target.; ATTACK: Transfer pieces to the new weakness.
PIECE JOB	CONTACT: The advancing pawn must make the larger chain decide.; RECAPTURE: The resulting pawn arrangement determines the target.; PRESSURE: Your rooks and minor pieces must be ready to attack it.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PURPOSE: The advance creates a target, not a race.; PIECES: Pressure must be ready before contact.; RECAPTURE: Structure depends on who takes how.; COUNTERPLAY: Do not ignore action on the other wing.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A minority attack succeeds when the new weakness lasts longer than the pawn push.

13. Use A Passed Pawn As A Tool



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Improve support and create play elsewhere while the opponent remains tied to the pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

DISTRACT: Which enemy piece must watch the pawn?; SUPPORT: Who controls the next square?; DIVERT: What target opens when defenders move?; TIMING: Does pushing improve or release them?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push every passed pawn' with 'Improve support before advancing.'; Replace 'Promotion is the only goal' with 'Use the pawn to tie pieces down.'; Replace 'Protect it with everything' with 'Create a second threat elsewhere.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

A passed pawn is strongest when the opponent must fear its future.

13. Decision Framework

Use A Passed Pawn As A Tool

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SECURE: Control the square ahead.; TIE: Force an enemy piece to blockade.; IMPROVE: Activate your remaining pieces.; DIVERT: Create play on the other side.; PUSH: Advance when the defender must concede.
PIECE JOB	DISTRACTION: A defender may be forced into permanent guarding duty.; SUPPORT: The pawn advances safely when pieces control its path.; DIVERSION: The enemy king or rook may be pulled away from another weakness.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RESTRAINT: A blockaded defender may still be a victory.; SUPPORT: Pieces escort more safely than the king alone.; TWO FRONTS: Use the pawn to open a distant target.; TIMING: Do not push away your own leverage.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

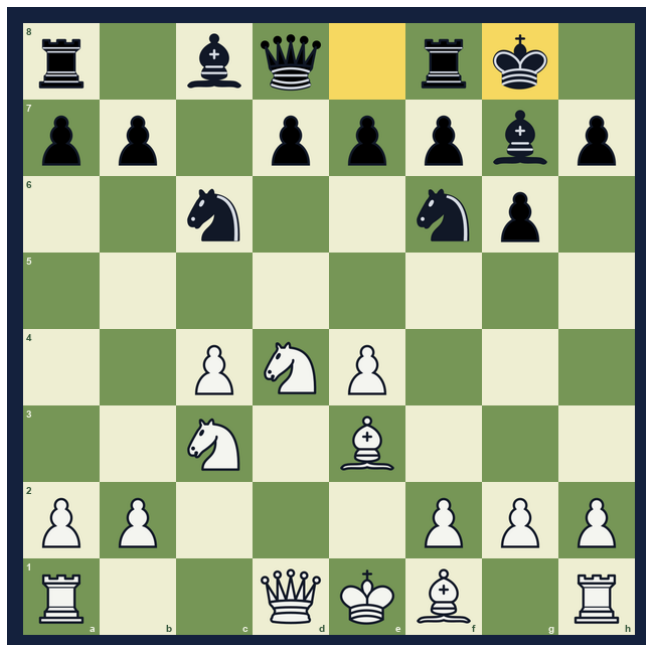
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A passed pawn is strongest when the opponent must fear its future.

14. Knight Or Bishop?



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Choose the piece whose strengths match the likely pawn breaks and targets.

PRIMARY PLAN

STABILITY: Does the knight have a lasting square?; RANGE: Can the bishop influence both sides?; CHANGE: Which pawn break is likely?; TARGETS: What must the piece attack or defend?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Closed means knight' with 'Check whether the knight has a route.'; Replace 'Bishop pair is always best' with 'Judge actual diagonals and future breaks.'; Replace 'Trade my bad piece' with 'Compare what the opponent keeps.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

The better minor piece is the one with a useful future.

14. Decision Framework

Knight Or Bishop?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FORECAST: Picture the likely pawn structure.; SQUARES: Find stable knight destinations.; DIAGONALS: Trace useful bishop routes.; TARGETS: Match each piece to future work.; CHOOSE: Keep the piece with the clearer future.
PIECE JOB	STABILITY: Knights need secure squares near relevant targets.; RANGE: Bishops gain value when play exists on both wings.; CHANGE: A pawn break can reverse which minor piece is superior.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUTURE: Minor-piece value changes with structure.; SQUARES: Knights require stable access.; RANGE: Bishops thrive with distant targets.; TRADE: Compare the pieces that remain, not those exchanged.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

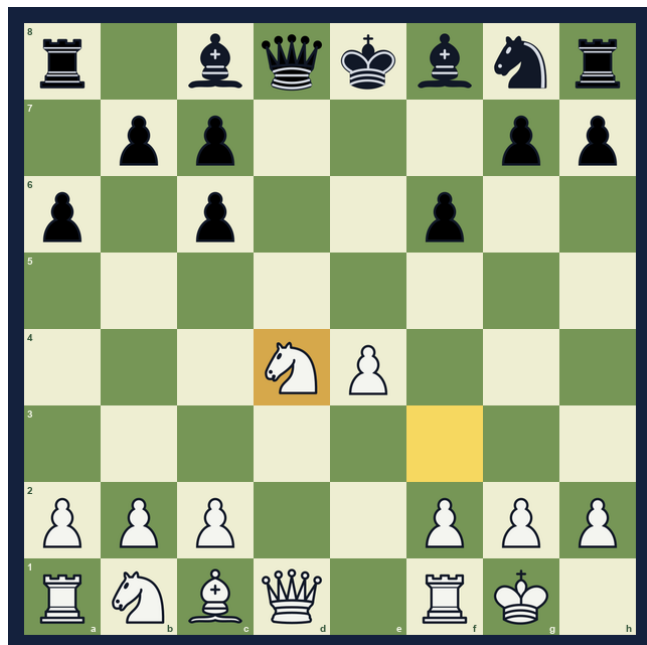
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The better minor piece is the one with a useful future.

15. Find The King'S Entry Route



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Trace the safe path and check which enemy move can deny entry.

PRIMARY PLAN

DESTINATION: What useful square must the king reach?;
ROUTE: Which safe path gets there fastest?; DENIAL: How can the opponent block entry?; TEMPO: Can a waiting move preserve the route?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Centralize the king' with 'Choose a concrete destination first.'; Replace 'Take the shortest route' with 'Check whether it can be blocked.'; Replace 'Win a nearby pawn' with 'Compare it with deeper king penetration.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

In an endgame, do not move the king toward the center; move it toward a job.

15. Decision Framework

Find The King'S Entry Route

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TARGET: Name the king's useful destination.; TRACE: Count safe routes to it.; OPPONENT: Find their best denial move.; TEMPO: Use waiting moves if needed.; ENTER: Choose the route that preserves access.
PIECE JOB	DESTINATION: Choose the pawn or square the king must reach.; ROUTE: Several safe paths may differ by one decisive tempo.; DENIAL: The opponent's king or pawn can close the entry door.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DESTINATION: Centralization is a means, not the goal.; ROUTE: King paths are calculation lines.; DENIAL: Prevent the opponent closing the door.; TEMPO: One move can decide who enters first.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In an endgame, do not move the king toward the center; move it toward a job.

16. Opposition Is About Access



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Use direct or distant opposition only when it wins access to a needed square.

PRIMARY PLAN

ENTRY: Which square must your king access?; GEOMETRY: Which king controls the crossing squares?; TEMPO: Who is forced to move first?; RESERVE: Is a pawn move available as a waiting move?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Take opposition automatically' with 'Name the entry square it should win.'; Replace 'Kings must face directly' with 'Use distant geometry when appropriate.'; Replace 'Push a pawn for progress' with 'Save pawn moves as tempo reserves.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

Remember the doorway you want, not merely the picture of two kings.

16. Decision Framework

Opposition Is About Access

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DESTINATION: Choose the penetration square.; CONTROL: Map the neighboring king squares.; FACE: Use opposition to force displacement.; WAIT: Spend a reserve tempo if needed.; ENTER: Take the route that becomes available.
PIECE JOB	ENTRY: Identify the square your king needs to cross.; GEOMETRY: Kings control adjacent squares and can force detours.; TEMPO: A spare pawn move can transfer the obligation to move.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ACCESS: Opposition is a tool for entry.; GEOMETRY: The kings' controlled squares decide movement.; TEMPO: Being forced to move can lose access.; RESERVE: A pawn move may be more valuable unplayed.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Remember the doorway you want, not merely the picture of two kings.

17. Calculate Pawn Races Reliably



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Calculate promotion, checks, capture routes, and whose new queen acts first.

PRIMARY PLAN

TEMPO: Count moves to promotion exactly.; CHECK: Does either promotion give check?; INTERCEPT: Can the new queen stop the other pawn?; KING: Can a king enter the pawn's square?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Both need four moves' with 'Check whose promotion has tempo.'; Replace 'First queen wins' with 'See whether the queen can intercept.'; Replace 'The king is too far' with 'Use the square rule before assuming.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

In a pawn race, calculate beyond promotion to the first meaningful action.

17. Decision Framework

Calculate Pawn Races Reliably

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COUNT: Measure each pawn's promotion time.; PROMOTE: Picture the exact promotion square.; CHECK: Test immediate checking moves.; INTERCEPT: Trace the new queen's route.; VERIFY: Include both kings and legal captures.
PIECE JOB	TEMPO: Whose pawn promotes first under best play?; CHECK: Promotion with check can gain a decisive extra move.; INTERCEPTION: A queen or king may stop the rival pawn after promotion.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	EXACT: One tempo decides many races.; CHECK: Promotion with check changes move order.; QUEEN: The first useful queen move matters.; KING: Apply the square rule before calculating long lines.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In a pawn race, calculate beyond promotion to the first meaningful action.

18. Choose Activity In Rook Endgames



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Seek checks, attacks from the side or rear, and access behind passed pawns.

PRIMARY PLAN

CHECKS: Can the rook check from a safe distance?; BEHIND: Can it get behind a passed pawn?; TARGETS: Which pawn can it attack with tempo?; KING: Can activity help your king enter?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Defend every pawn' with 'Allow one pawn if activity compensates.'; Replace 'Put the rook beside the pawn' with 'Seek the rear whenever possible.'; Replace 'Check from close range' with 'Keep checking distance from the king.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

In rook endings, a busy rook is often worth more than a protected pawn.

18. Decision Framework

Choose Activity In Rook Endgames

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FREE: Release the rook from passive duty.; BEHIND: Occupy the rear of the passed pawn.; CHECK: Use lateral or rear checking distance.; ATTACK: Target pawns with tempo.; ACTIVATE: Bring your king toward the action.
PIECE JOB	CHECKS: Distance lets the rook check without being attacked.; BEHIND: Rooks usually work best behind passed pawns.; TARGETS: Attacking enemy pawns creates time for your king.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ACTIVITY: An active rook can save material deficits.; DISTANCE: Checks are safer from far away.; BEHIND: Passed pawns are easiest to control from the rear.; KING: Rook activity creates king-entry time.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

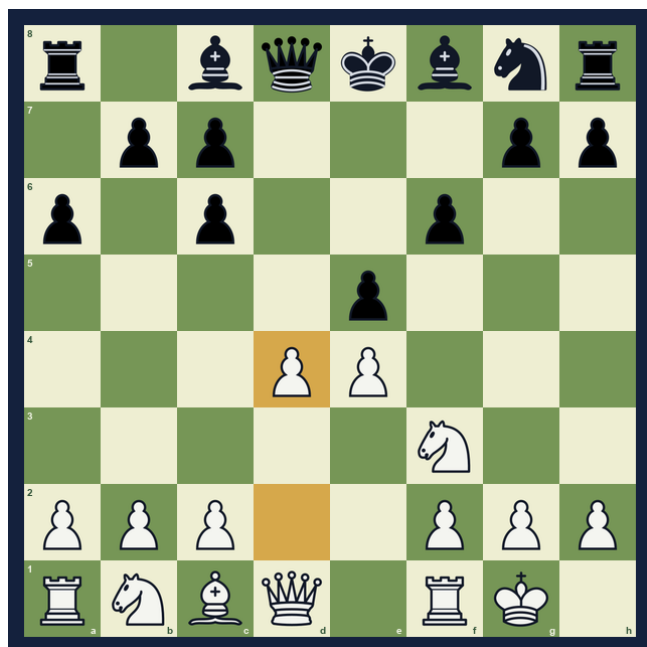
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In rook endings, a busy rook is often worth more than a protected pawn.

19. Convert An Extra Pawn



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Activate the king and pieces, restrict counterplay, then use the majority to create a passed pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

KING: Can your king reach the stronger side?; EXCHANGE: Which enemy piece creates counterplay?; MAJORITY: Where can you create a passed pawn?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource must be stopped?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push the extra pawn' with 'Improve the king before committing pawns.'; Replace 'Trade everything' with 'Exchange activity, not useful helpers.'; Replace 'Protect every pawn' with 'Permit harmless losses for a winning passer.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

19. Decision Framework

Convert An Extra Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACTIVATE: Improve the king first.; RESTRICT: Remove the opponent's active resource.; EXCHANGE: Trade the piece that creates resistance.; CREATE: Use the majority to make a passer.; ESCORT: Advance with coordinated support.
PIECE JOB	KING: The king must help attack and escort pawns.; EXCHANGES: Trade active enemy pieces, not every piece automatically.; MAJORITY: Use the extra pawn to create a protected or distant passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ACTIVITY: Material needs active help.; SELECTIVE: Not every exchange improves conversion.; PASSER: The extra pawn must gain a useful role.; CONTROL: Stop counterplay before racing.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

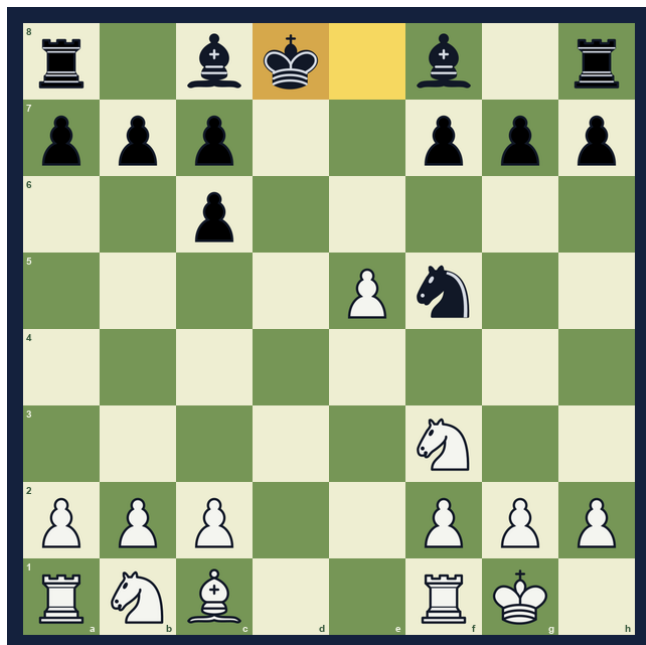
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

20. Defend A Worse Position



ENDGAME FUNDAMENTALS

READ THE POSITION

Reduce the opponent's easiest plan while preserving one source of counterplay.

PRIMARY PLAN

PLAN: What is their easiest winning plan?; TRADE: Which exchange disrupts it most?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource can you preserve?; FORTRESS: Can you build a stable defensive setup?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I should wait' with 'Force the opponent to solve a new problem.'; Replace 'Trade anything' with 'Trade the piece that enables their plan.'; Replace 'Create random threats' with 'Preserve credible, sustainable counterplay.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

20. Decision Framework

Defend A Worse Position

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Evaluate the position without panic.; PREDICT: Name their simplest plan.; DISRUPT: Trade, blockade, or change structure.; ACTIVATE: Create one serious source of play.; RESIST: Make every step require accuracy.
PIECE JOB	RESISTANCE: Identify the plan they would choose with unlimited time.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes that plan simple.; COUNTERPLAY: Keep one credible threat or pawn break alive.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NOT LOST: A disadvantage is an evaluation, not a result.; DIFFICULTY: Your job is to complicate conversion.; TARGETED TRADE: Remove the key winning piece.; ACTIVE: Keep one resource the opponent must respect.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.